

Virtue Ethics

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Student Materials

- web
- PDF

Overview

Ethics background required: None

Subject matter referred to in this lab: Assignments in courses

Placement in overall ethics curriculum:

- Academic year: First year, first semester, probably introductory statistics, data science, or programming course
- Recommended previous labs: A First Look at Ethics in Computer and Data Science (this lab is designed to be completed as homework)
- Recommended follow-up labs: Analogies (Code Plagiarism)

Time required: Out of class: None; In class: 20-30 minutes

Learning objectives:

- Students further understand how the virtue ethics framework works
- Students practice applying the virtue ethics framework to scenarios
- Students learn to articulate which virtues might shape decisions and actions using the virtue ethics framework
- Students consider how virtues are developed as positive character traits

Ethical issue to be considered: Several scenarios related to a course.

Flow

- Students are reminded of what a virtue is
- Students are reminded of what the virtue ethics framework is
- Activity: Students work in small groups to determine how a virtuous person would respond in four different scenarios

- Reflection: Groups compare notes on virtuous responses and ponder how/why their ideas may differ

Preparation required: Read the entire lab several times. Print a copy of the student handout for each student in the class. Have a copy of the “professor answers” available in case you need them.

Guide for Instructors

Lesson plan

Introduction (to be read or summarized to class) (3 minutes)

Virtues can be defined as character traits — qualities that impact how we feel, think, and act — that we can cultivate through intentional practice, and that in turn shape our practice and action. Virtues are good character traits. We might usefully distinguish virtues — moral qualities of a person — from personality traits that are not specifically moral. For example, being an optimistic person or an extrovert, or having leadership qualities or aptitude for higher math might often be beneficial or good traits to have, but they are not necessarily moral traits (i.e., they can be used to do bad actions, accomplish bad ends, or lead to personal corruption). Virtues are traits like kindness, wisdom, justice, and faithfulness — qualities of character that, as the Greek philosopher Aristotle put it, make people good and make their actions good too (Nichomachean Ethics ii.6).

Since the virtue ethics framework asks the question “what would a virtuous person do?” to determine what is right, if we want to use this framework it is important to look at these positive character traits and understand how they might inform the decisions of a virtuous person.

You will be considering several scenarios and trying to determine how a virtuous person would respond. You will have the opportunity to list which virtues you think would most influence the response.

Discussion Guidelines

In this lab, students are asked to openly discuss virtues. To encourage authentic engagement with the material and each other, you may need to state some guidelines on expectations of peer-to-peer interaction. Here are two suggestions from “Guidelines For Classroom Interactions,” the Center for Research on Learning & Teaching, University of Michigan, <http://crlt.umich.edu/examples-discussion-guidelines>.

1. Understand that your words have effects on others. Speak with care. If you learn that something you have said was experienced as disrespectful or marginalizing, listen carefully and try to understand that perspective. Learn how you can do better in the future.

2. Understand that others will come to these discussions with different experiences from yours. Be careful about assumptions and generalizations you make based only on your experience. Be open to hearing and learning from other perspectives.

Ask students to keep these guidelines (or other similar guidelines) in mind as they discuss the scenarios in this lab.

Activity (7-10 minutes)

Pass out papers with scenarios or point them to the scenarios you have posted online. Allow students to consider the four scenarios either as individuals or in small groups (3-4 students). Groups are probably best if it is possible and they can be kept small.

Changing it up

You could easily modify this activity by

- adding additional virtues to the list,
- modifying or replacing the particular scenarios,
- asking students to compare and contrast highly valued virtues in different cultures.

Reflection (to be completed in class after the activity is finished) (10 minutes)

Suggestions for guiding student reflection:

1. As time allows, consider each scenario as a class and have groups share their thoughts.
 - Professor made very hard assignment — could be honest and ask for suggestions from students (virtues: hospitality, humility, transparency)
 - Friend asks for help at last minute — help as much as possible but ensure the work is the friend's own (virtues: integrity, compassion, patience, kindness)
 - Last minute question for Lab Assistant — look at the error and suggest ways the student can find it (virtues: integrity, compassion, professionalism, respect)
 - Heavy workload with grumbling students — figure out how much time is actually spent, identify valid complaints (virtues: patience, integrity, respect, initiative, honesty)
2. It is quite possible that students will reach different conclusions about what a virtuous person would do. Consider with the class what to make of this.
 - Are some virtues to be ranked more highly?
 - This discovery should lead to mentioning that a single ethical framework might not be enough. That is why we will be looking at other frameworks.
3. Ask the class if they think they would naturally respond in a virtuous way or if it would be hard.
4. Ask the class what the benefits might be for a virtuous response for each of the scenarios.

Wrap Up (To be read or summarized)

We are not born with virtues, we develop them over a lifetime through practice, imitating role models, and reflecting on how the world around us forms our character.

Virtue ethicists suggest a number of ways to cultivate virtue and good character:

- Repeated intentional action. Deliberately set out to create new habits. Structure your environment to give you reminders and make your new practices easier.
- Join a community of people who already have and exercise this virtue.
- Find a role model who has this virtue and spend time with that person, paying attention to their assessments and reactions to situations.

Assessment

1. Ask students to define “virtue.”
 - Morally positive character traits
2. Ask students to describe how the virtue ethics framework could be applied to an ethical dilemma.
3. Ask students to reflect on two different virtues and indicate which (if either) they think is more important and why.
4. What are some of the challenges of using the virtue ethics framework alone?
 - Relative importance of virtues differ between people
 - Sometimes hard to find the ‘better of 2 difficult choices’
5. Give an example of acting virtuously along with the benefits it could produce.

Bibliography